

Multitasking is the Mindkiller Video Transcript

What if I told you that multitasking is a lie and the tactic we've all been using to try and get more done every day is in actuality slowing us down and making us miserable? You're probably aware we live in the age of information, but we also live in the age of interruption and distraction. Many of us feel constantly bombarded with notifications, pings, dings, badges, constant demands of our attention. It's like busy is the new normal, but I would even say busy is a status symbol.

I know the busiest I've ever been was a few years ago when I was attempting to work full time, go to grad school part time, care for my newborn infant at home, and also run a business in my free time. Anybody else in that club? That was also one of the most stressed out and miserable time periods of my entire life. During that time, since I was in grad school and had to do research anyway, I got curious about these feelings of anxiety and overwhelm, like if I had all these great things going for me, why was I still so miserable? And as I was reading, researching, I came across something really interesting in the literature.

I learned that multitasking is physically impossible for the human brain. We cannot focus on more than one thing at a time. It takes more cognitive effort to switch back and forth between two things than it would to just pick one and get it done.

Yes, we can manage to listen to a podcast while we clean the house, but coherently replying to an email while also listening to somebody speak in a Zoom meeting, well, we're not doing as good a job as we think we are. What we're actually doing is not multitasking. It's called continuous partial attention.

Continuously paying partial attention to everything happening to and around us during the day. The difference here is subtle. Multitasking is something we do to save time or be more efficient.

Kind of like how I always used to practice this talk in the shower. I can run through this in my head while I'm taking a shower. Doesn't take a lot of thought to wash my hair.

However, continuous partial attention is driven by a need to feel connected. It's associated with the fear of missing out. It's a term originally coined by Linda Stone to describe our tendency to try to keep up with several modes of communication at one time.

So that's like stopping in the middle of replying to an email in order to respond to the text you just got while also still glancing at the IM coming through on your computer screen. Both of these things, continuous partial attention and multitasking require the brain to pick one thing to focus on and then switch back and forth between the two or the three or the four, however many things we have going on at once. The difference is the amount of focus required for the task as well as the reason why we're trying to do so many things at once in the first place.

So, again, multitasking. Something we do to save time. That's like cleaning the dishes while we wait on the cookies to bake in the oven.

It's not responding and reacting to every single notification, message, email, phone call, text that we could get during the day. Kind of like my daughter with her phone on her scooter. She's very dangerous, y'all.

You should watch out. So you may be asking, Lindsay, what's the big deal? Everybody's doing this. This is how we have to keep up and we've been doing it this way for years.

But that's exactly the problem. Over time, this constant reactivity becomes our default mode. We've created a habit out of being perpetually on and available.

This is changing the neural pathways in our brains. The more we try to keep up with all the technological communication coming at us, the more we forget how to engage in meaningful face-to-face communication. And this is damaging our ability to create and maintain genuine relationships.

Consider a study that was done by the Kaiser Foundation in 2018. At that time, about one in five Americans reported that they always feel lonely. About 20%.

Fast forward to January 2020, and that number jumps to three in five. 60% of Americans saying they always feel lonely. And that was before the pandemic hit this country.

All of this is complicated by the fact that notifications on our phones and computers elicit a dopamine response. Dopamine is the chemical associated with really pleasurable activities like eating something really delicious, gambling and winning or having sex. It's the reward chemical that keeps us coming back again and again and again.

So responding to notifications can be more than a habit. It can be downright addictive. In fact, nearly 50% of Americans admit they feel addicted to their phones.

Half of us. So we know. We know our phones are ruling our lives.

We know we feel overwhelmed and overworked. But we tell ourselves as soon as things calm down at work, as soon as the kids start school or go to college, as soon as I can just get ahead, then I'll calm down. Then I won't be so busy.

But does life ever slow down? We have to make a choice to make a change. We can't go on like this, addicted to our phones, constantly feeling lonely. We don't have to be slaves to our phones, to our jobs, to our own endless to do lists.

Making a choice to make a change is a great first step. And if it was as easy as, well, not going to do that anymore, I wouldn't be standing here talking to you about how our overscheduled lives are making us miserable. But the really good news is our brains are malleable.

And with a little persistence, we can retrain our own brains to create new, healthier habits. Most of us would agree. We want to increase our productivity.

But we want to do it with less stress and less damage to our important relationships. And there's a method that you can use that can calm your mind, ease anxiety, improve your mood, increase your productivity. And it's probably not what you think.

Mindfulness. Mindfulness is paying attention and maintaining focus in the current moment. Basically the opposite of continuous partial attention.

With mindfulness, rather than being frantic and mindlessly reacting to everything coming at us during the day, we're able to pause and reflect so that we can maintain focus and presence of mind in the current moment. What's the best way to quit an old habit? Replace it. Simply replace it.

And there's a pretty great book by Charles Duhigg called *The Power of Habit*. In it, he reveals another secret to lasting habit change. Not only do we need to replace our original behavior with something new, we also need to understand why we're doing that behavior in the first place.

What need are we trying to meet? Or what craving are we trying to fill with this behavior? If you remember, continuous partial attention is driven by a need to feel connected. But we've also realized that this feeling of connection is false. It's fleeting at best.

Trying to do all the things and be all the places doesn't make us feel more connected or more productive. It's doing the opposite, actually. And even though mindfulness is a personal lifestyle choice, the research shows it does facilitate unity and connection in relationships.

More mindful people have more satisfying relationships. And as counterintuitive as it may seem, more mindful people also get more done. So by replacing our continuous partial attention habit with mindfulness, we're meeting our need with a healthier, more effective method.

That has tons of benefits, by the way, because not only does mindfulness improve our relationships and increase our productivity, it also assists us with the way we view stress in the first place. So rather than spending our energy worrying about things that haven't even happened yet or ruminating on things that have already happened, mindfulness allows us to pause and reflect and to consciously choose our thoughts and behaviors. I learned this lesson the hard way, many years ago, before I knew any of this stuff.

My boss at the time emailed me asking to have an unexpected meeting the next day. And my autopilot response at that time was to immediately start freaking out. Like, what have I done wrong? What am I about to get confronted on? Do I need to start updating my resume? I spent the rest of that day and the next morning until the meeting just worrying.

And it turned out to be totally benign meeting. Had nothing to do with me or anything I'd done or not done, but I'd wasted all that time worrying. A more mindful response would have been to realize, whew, Lindsay, you're freaking out a little bit.

Maybe you need to take some deep breaths or, I don't know, ask some questions or something, but this isn't going to work. But I didn't know that at the time. So I spent a lot of time worrying and freaking out.

So when you're getting started with mindfulness, remember that even our thoughts and reactions can be habits. And changing your habits can take some time. It is possible.

Even just a few minutes a day makes a big difference. Remember that with mindfulness, the goal is not to stop your thoughts or control them. I mean, if we stopped our thoughts, we'd be dead, and that's not what we're aiming for.

We want to direct our thoughts and consciously choose them. We want to be aware of our thoughts, but not necessarily become them. Making a choice to make a change is step one.

Step two is actually following through with that change. Do we really want to continue living stressed out, frantic, lonely lives? I know I don't. This really hit home for me a few months ago when I was picking up my daughter from daycare.

And again, she was one of the last kids there because, again, I had worked late. And as her teacher's walking her to the door, she's grabbing her backpack, and my daughter gestures at me and says, yeah, that's my mom. She works all the time.

And I had to hold back tears all the way to the car because that is not the image I want my daughter to have of me. That is not the image I want my daughter to have of what it means to be an adult. I want her to live a calm, peaceful, balanced life.

I want you to live a calm, peaceful, balanced life. But understand that multitasking doesn't exist in this world of technological overload and distraction. Continuous partial attention is making us miserable and damaging our relationships.

Something has to change, and I believe it's us. Thank you.